arts (dance, drama, music, painting, etc.), six subjects in all. It made for a well-rounded education, more preferred by US universities but not compatible with our stream system. No matter what combination, the 'best of four criteria' for admission to any stream in Indian universities could not be met. As it so happened, most of Amala's schoolmates were applying to foreign varsities and so did she, also giving her SAT exam and getting a reasonably good score. Based on this, Amala was able to secure admission to the Singapore Management University (SMU) in a four-year Bachelor of Business Administration (BBA) programme starting in August 2008. She got her first job immediately after graduating, with Rice Communications, an independent strategic communications consultancy firm, and has been working in Singapore ever since, albeit with different companies. Our decision to take Amala with us to Myanmar paid off in the long run.

A number of countries such as Singapore and Israel did not have any Defence Attaché. The absence of a uniformed person, especially in a country with a military dispensation, left them handicapped. One day the Ambassador of Singapore, Mr Robert Chua, rang me up requesting for a meeting. I was not quite sure of how to respond, so I went to our Ambassador for advice. Ambassador Mitra had no hesitation in giving me the go-ahead. Of course, I should go and meet him he said, and any others too, no issues as far as he was concerned. However, he cautioned that whenever I did go to such meetings, I should put in an obligatory report, informing him of the meeting. This he said, was for my own safety, to rule out any espionage angle. This is something that would never have occurred to me. These requests were usually from countries that did not have a resident DA of their own and hence wanted to know my views on the situation in Myanmar from a military perspective. I met

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